REPO RADAR

# Ponytail: setup guide

**What it is.** Ponytail is an MIT-licensed "skill" for AI coding agents. It is a short markdown file (52 lines in `skills/ponytail/SKILL.md`) that tells your agent to make the smallest change that fully solves the task: reuse what exists, use the standard library, never add a dependency for a few lines, and never cut validation, error handling or security.

- Repo: https://github.com/DietrichGebert/ponytail
- Author: Dietrich Gebert · License: MIT

## Install

**Claude Code** (two separate prompts):

```
/plugin marketplace add DietrichGebert/ponytail
/plugin install ponytail@ponytail
```

**Codex:**

```
codex plugin marketplace add DietrichGebert/ponytail
codex plugin add ponytail@ponytail
```

Then open `/hooks` in Codex and trust its lifecycle hooks.

**Any other agent:** copy `AGENTS.md` from the repo into your project, or ask your agent to install `skills/ponytail/SKILL.md` as a skill. Step by step for other agents: `INSTALL.md` in the repo.

Only install it from `DietrichGebert/ponytail` on GitHub or `@dietrichgebert/ponytail` on npm.

## 3 ways to use it

1. **Daily coding.** Leave it on and compare the diffs your agent produces. Levels: `/ponytail lite|full|ultra`.

2. **Reviews.** The repo ships review and audit skills (`ponytail-review`, `ponytail-audit`) to flag over-built code.
3. **A/B test on one task.** Give the same task to your agent with and without the skill, then compare the diff size and the tests.

## What we tested (and what we did not)

- Cloned in a locked sandbox (no keys, no tokens), Node v22.22.0, `node --test tests/*.test.js`.
- Result: 144 tests, 143 passed, 1 failed, about 6 seconds.
- The failure is `csv: correct pandas one-liner passes`. That test runs a Python snippet that imports pandas, which is not installed in our sandbox: an environment gap, not a confirmed bug.
- **Not tested:** the savings claims (53% less code, 41% less time, 26% less cost, 45% fewer tokens, 98% vs 68% of risky logic with a test). They come from the author's own benchmark (39 tasks, 5 runs each, README of the repo); we did not reproduce them.

## Sources

- Repo and README: https://github.com/DietrichGebert/ponytail (MIT, © 2026 DietrichGebert)
- Star count: Repo Radar GitHub snapshot, 2026-10-23 (174,739 stars)

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